

C20 B HISTORICAL ACKNOWLEDGEMENT | O (MAX : 1 PT)

Intent : To acknowledge and honor historical rights, ownership and occupation of land and/or recognize significant societal contributions of marginalized communities.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects to develop a comprehensive program that acknowledges the history of colonization, displacement and relocation and/or the significant contributions that Indigenous, enslaved and migrant peoples have made to a particular place.

Issue : Specific ethnic and racial populations have historically been colonized, enslaved, marginalized, abused and neglected (for the purposes of this feature, collectively referred to as "marginalized" communities), with the threat of erasure due to imperial power dynamics, laws and decrees across the globe. These communities were the original stewards of land and biodiversity for millennia, making significant contributions to society through traditional and ancient knowledge.¹⁻³ On a global scale, Indigenous Peoples and people across the African diaspora have witnessed their rightful and sacred lands being taken against their will through Doctrine of Discovery, broken agreements, and abuse of eminent domain and legal constructs such as heirs' property laws.⁴⁻⁶ In the United States, communities of color, such as Asian and African Americans, have made significant contributions to the building of the country through forced and unjust labor.^{2,3} In addition, significant contributions through forced labor have occurred in South America and the Caribbean region.⁶⁻⁹ The harmful impacts of global colonization have led to disparities in physical, mental, emotional and economic well-being, long-term displacement, erased histories, and a breakdown of community, social and economic structures, the effects of which have passed down through generations.¹⁰⁻¹² Studies have shown this has caused historical trauma and that the mental health of Indigenous youth still suffers on the Historical Loss Scale.¹³ This intergenerational trauma has been found in DNA at the cellular level.¹⁴ In Australia, New Zealand and North America, recent truth and reconciliation acknowledgments, laws and reparations have begun for Indigenous People who have suffered various human rights violations, including land rights abuse and attempted genocide.^{4,12,15} It is important that organizations work with representatives from within the affected community and/or Tribal Nation to ensure that their acknowledgement and reconciliation and/or reparations programs do no harm, as defined by the community.

Solutions : This feature seeks to acknowledge and begin reconciliation for at least a portion of the valuable contributions from affected populations by encouraging healing and connection that is grounded in place and culturally-relevant values.¹⁶⁻²⁰ The act of reconciliation illuminates and drives awareness of historical contributions of marginalized and colonized communities through action and future-facing programs (i.e., land acknowledgments, truth and reconciliation practices, empowerment programs, financial relief and economic development).

PART 1 PROVIDE HISTORICAL ACKNOWLEDGEMENT (MAX : 1 PT)

For All Spaces:

The project or organization develops and implements a comprehensive historical acknowledgment program that meets the following requirements:

- a. Review land deeds, historical records, census data or other credible sources (e.g., articles, websites, surveys) to identify a community that has historically suffered as a result of colonization, displacement and relocation.
- b. Conduct an assessment to determine if any of the organization's current practices or policies are harmful to the community receiving acknowledgment, including, at a minimum, the following:
 1. Discriminatory and harmful labor practices and the implicit biases, policies and structures that lead to them, including those impacting consultants and subcontractors (e.g., collaborative partnerships that may cause representational damage, poor working conditions, participation in modern slavery and privatized prison labor, salary inequity, discriminatory hiring practices and/or lack of representation in leadership).
 2. Occupancy on sacred land (e.g., burial sites, spiritual sites), land protected treaty or agreement (e.g., hunting and gathering rights), or seized land (e.g., by use of eminent domain).
 3. Practices that negatively impact all life and the environment, especially those in closest proximity to the project site (e.g., pollution, deforestation, poor waste management practices).
- c. Create a program for historical acknowledgement that:
 1. Is informed by members and leaders of the community and/or Tribal Nation, as identified through one or more meetings with community representatives.
 2. Acknowledges the beliefs and practices of the community and/or Tribal Nation.
 3. Promotes engagement including reconciliation and/or reparations (as applicable) between the organization and the community and/or Tribal Nation.
 4. Identifies a minimum three-year plan of action for how the organization will develop a meaningful relationship with the community and/or Tribal Nation that will benefit the community (e.g., employment incubator, mental health support, funding agreement, education opportunities, returning land or property).
 5. Includes a signed document acknowledging the partnership demonstrating the program was co-created between the organization and the community and/or Tribal Nation.
- d. Develop a communication plan in a physical or electronic format that provides:
 1. Education for employees and the general public about the community and/or Tribal Nation's historical contribution to society.
 2. Background on the historical acknowledgement program and its development, as well as opportunities for employees to engage with the plan of action.
- e. Express historical context publicly through at least one of the following methods:
 1. Mission statement
 2. Monument
 3. Proclamation
 4. Educational display

5. Plaque
6. Website
7. Restoration of Indigenous names of landmarks
8. Other expressions of historical acknowledgement

Note : This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the world.

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